

Why the Cycling Movement **MATTERS**

AS I CONTEMPLATE what to type for my first editorial, my thoughts turn to the question of why I am so passionate about working for **MOMENTUM**. Really, it comes down to values. As a commuter cyclist, I want to see better road infrastructure, safer and healthier communities and cleaner air. Being part of **MOMENTUM MAGAZINE** is one way for me to realize these goals.

Increasing cycling mode share on urban roads is a mission shared by millions worldwide. Indeed, the commuter cycling movement was forged by men and women who have fought long and hard for better bike infrastructure, a fair share of the road and safer, healthier communities. It's a movement that began at the grassroots level and is now becoming part of mainstream culture.

From my point of view, cycling is the perfect mode of transportation. For me, it's a reason to avoid the gym, enjoy the outdoors and save money and the planet at the same

time. It's also a way to meet people and develop lasting friendships.

But there are still challenges ahead. As cities densify, drivers, pedestrians and cyclists are increasingly competing for a scarce resource: road space. This can lead to tragic consequences.

On January 8, Christopher Thompson, a 60-year-old doctor, was sentenced to five years in prison for slamming on the brakes in front of two cyclists on a narrow road in Brentwood, LA. One of the cyclists, Ron Peterson, suffered a broken nose, broken teeth and cuts to his face; the other, Christian Stoehr, a separated shoulder. The judge presiding over the case called it a "wake-up call," noting that cyclists are particularly vulnerable on roads and adding that local members of government need to be proactive and create more bike lanes.

There is an urgent need for better cycling infrastructure in our cities. Not only painted lines on pavement, but bike lanes that are separate from busy roads, provide enough



EDITORIAL
SARAH RIPPLINGER

space for cyclists to pass one another safely, incorporate road crossing signals into the design, include clear signage and accommodate a variety of cycling abilities and needs.

In this issue, we take a look at trailblazers in the US and Canada who have lobbied, educated, rallied and collaborated to lay the foundations of bicycle advocacy and positive change in local communities and on a national and international level. Jeff Mapes, author of *Pedaling Revolution*, taps the roots of the innovative and courageous individuals who forged the path we are presently pedaling. It is because of their work and the work of so many others, including people like you, that commuter cycling has become an integral part of modern lifestyles. 🚲

Keep those spokes spinning,
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TRAILBLAZERS



BY JEFF MAPES

If you spend much time pedaling the streets of any city in North America, you're probably pretty passionate about it. You know what it's like to be part of a small and all-too-often embattled minority – and you probably also believe the world would be a better place if a lot more people got out of their cars and joined you on bikes.

These simple feelings have given rise to an increasingly sophisticated bike advocacy movement that has grown across the US and Canada over the last four decades. Cycling, once seen as only suitable for children and oddly attired athletes, is now becoming a mainstream form of transportation in cities from San Francisco to New York, from Montreal to Vancouver, BC.

This hasn't been easy and the movement is still a long way from reaching its full potential. That's partly because organizing cyclists – who are often contrary and individualistic by nature – is a bit like herding cats. No single organization is the cycling equivalent of the National Rifle Association. No one figure is as towering as Martin Luther King was to the civil rights movement.

Instead, the modern bike movement is more akin to a thousand flowers blooming – sometimes in the unlikeliest of settings.

Take Deb Hubsmith, who just over a decade ago was lugging materials on sustainable transportation around to local

schools in suburban Marin County, CA on a solar-powered electrical bike. In the space of a few years, Hubsmith – who headed the Marin County Bicycle Coalition – formed a lobbying alliance with powerful Minnesota congressman Rep. Jim Oberstar, who had fallen in love with cycling himself. She helped push through hundreds of millions of dollars for new biking programs, including the creation of a national program to encourage children to once again walk and bike to school.

Or consider Randy Neufeld, who built the Chicagoland Bicycle Federation into one of the most powerful local bike groups in the country by essentially embedding his staff within the City of Chicago's transportation department. Now they are writing bike plans for the city. And Neufeld has moved on to head the SRAM Cycling Fund, which was set up by the bicycle equipment manufacturer, and is handing out \$10 million in grants to bike advocacy groups.

Too mainstream for you? Well, there is Chris Carlsson, who nurtured San Francisco's Critical Mass and has seen it grow into a worldwide phenomenon. Or you can talk about the "underground" mutant bike builders or the loose-knit bike fun group Shift – in my hometown of Portland, OR – who are turning bikes into performance art and helping create a new kind of urban cool about cycling.

Canada has taken tips from the States,

How Bicycle Advocates Defined North American Cycling Culture (1970-2010)



A MODERN BICYCLING ADVOCACY TIMELINE

1973: The bicycle industry sells more than 15 million bikes in the US – more than double the sales of just three years before. The "Bike Boom" inspires the creation of bike advocacy groups throughout North America. Unfortunately, sales collapse in just a few years.

1973: The Arab oil embargo plays a major role in persuading Holland to develop modern bikeway infrastructure. The country's bikeway network soon becomes an inspiration for bike activists around the world. Some 27 percent of trips in the Netherlands are by bike.

• Bill Wilkinson and Dan Burden, 1974

1976: John Forester publishes the first edition of his book, *Effective Cycling*. Forester, a California industrial engineer and son of noted English novelist C.S. Forester, codified the rules of "vehicular cycling" that are the basis for bicycle education programs today. A passionate advocate of cyclists' right to the road, he eventually parts ways with much of the bike advocacy community, opposing virtually all bikeways – particularly bike lanes and European-style cycletracks.

• John Forester





◀ Paul Tsongas
Neil Goldschmidt ▶

1980: On Earth Day, then-Transportation Secretary Neil Goldschmidt and Massachusetts Sen. Paul Tsongas lead a procession of bicyclists up to Capitol Hill to deliver the first-ever government report on the virtues of encouraging bicycle commuting. The Bike Fed holds its first Pro Bike Conference in Asheville, NC. The biennial event is now called "Pro Walk Pro Bike." Ronald Reagan is elected president and his administration cuts funding for further studies of bicycle transportation. Photos by Bill Wilkinson



1986: Greg LeMond becomes the first American to win the Tour de France. It helps keep bicycling in the public eye in what was otherwise a difficult period for bike advocates. Suburban sprawl accelerates, children are increasingly not encouraged to cycle and many bicycle advocacy groups formed in the 1970s fade away. Photo by David Niddie

1986: Rails-to-Trails Conservancy is created to aid and encourage the conversion of abandoned rail lines into bicycling and walking trails.



Robert Silverman ▶

◀ Claire Morissette

Joe Breeze ▶

1977: In Marin County, CA, Joe Breeze begins building and selling the first bikes made especially for the emerging sport of "mountain bicycling." (Several others play an important role in "inventing" the mountain bike. For the full story see the film *Klunkerz*). Breeze builds on his experience and later develops his line of Breezer commuter bikes. Photo by Wende Cragg/Rolling Dinosaur Archive

Late 70s: Bikes on buses in CA. Photo courtesy Cycle & Recycle Calendar



1977: Bicycle activists create the Bicycle Federation, a Washington, DC-based organization. The Federation is a national clearinghouse for bicycle programs and pushes the federal government to do more for bicycling and to help promote bike advocacy groups. Bill Wilkinson, who helps found the Bike Fed, eventually becomes its executive director and plays a major role in nurturing the national bike lobby through the 1980s and 1990s. The group is now known as the National Center for Bicycling & Walking.

Bill Wilkinson ▶



where the main thrust of the cycling advocacy movement in North America began.

There's Robert "Bicycle Bob" Silverman whose madman antics in Montreal, QC in the 1970s sparked a revolution of bike advocacy in Canada. Silverman and a team of guerrilla protesters became famous for rallying against the "auto-crazy." They painted bike lanes in the middle of the night. They staged a "die-in" where hundreds lay, coated in fake blood, at the corner of St. Catherine and University streets beside mangled bicycles to raise awareness about the need to make roads safer and more accessible.

These demonstrations were also headed by Claire Morissette who, together with Silverman, formed *Le Monde à Bicyclette* in 1976, arguably the flagship cycling organization in Canada. Dubbed the "Joan of Arc" of bicycling, Morissette became famous for other publicity-raising stunts, such as bringing skis, ladders and cardboard elephants onto the subway system in Montreal, which were allowed, at a time when bicycles were prohibited. The City of Montreal recognized her work in 2007 by posthumously naming the De Maisonneuve bike path the Piste Cyclable Claire-Morissette.

These flowers didn't bloom by themselves. The seeds were planted in many places in North America, all the way back to the founding of the League of American Wheelman in 1880 in Newport, RI. Before hardly anyone had a car – let alone thought of having an automotive lobby – the league started lobbying for paved roads to replace the rutted, muddy dirt roads that connected cities.

But enough about ancient history. If you want to understand the modern bike movement in North America, you could well start in the Golden Temple, a Chinese restaurant in Washington, DC in 1977. A group of young bike activists who had started to meet decided they needed a wise head to help guide them. They sought out Tedson Meyers, a local attorney and former DC city councilor.

Meyers, then 49, had once bicycled

across France. But he too had despaired at how cycling was ignored by American transportation officials, despite a huge spurt in adult bike sales in the early 70s that became known as the "bike boom."

"At the time we began, people in positions of authority had no use for pedestrians and bicyclists," Meyers told me when I was researching my book, *Pedaling Revolution: How Cyclists are Changing American Cities*. "When I was on the DC city council, the head of the highway department – he was a lovely man – [...] thought that pedestrians and bikes just get in the way. The thing that irritated him the most was pedestrians who

"We had a change-the-world mentality... Nothing was impossible."
– Bill Wilkinson

would walk slowly across the intersection."

On a spring day 33 years ago, Meyers met three young bike enthusiasts at the Golden Temple. Dan Burden, then in his early 30s, was already a celebrity in the tight little world of bike activists. He led an epic trip from Alaska to Mexico that he chronicled for National Geographic and, in 1976, organized a mass "Bike-Centennial Ride" across the US. To him, the bike was a wonderful "learning machine" that allowed people to experience nature and their own community in a way they couldn't behind the windshield of a car. Two young federal bureaucrats trying to carve out a niche working on bike issues – Bill Wilkinson and Katie Moran – rounded out the group.

Over lunch, the four decided to create the Bicycle Federation, which they saw as a kind of nerve center for a true transportation revolution. "We wanted above all to train advocates in communities" around the country, Meyers said.



1990: Die-In on Walnut Bridge during grand opening, Philly, PA. Photo by Ken Yanoviak

1991: Congress passes the Intermodal Surface Transportation Efficiency Act, known as ISTEA. It is the first federal transportation bill that provides significant amounts of money for walking and bicycling.



Mia Birk ◀

1993: The City of Portland, OR, hires Mia Birk as bike coordinator and begins a comprehensive bike network. It becomes a model for bike advocates as the cycling mode share eventually climbs above 6 percent by 2008 – making it No. 1 among major US cities. Photo by Erin Janke

1994: The federal government releases the National Bicycling and Walking Study. It calls for doubling the percentage of short trips by cycle or on foot.

1996: Twenty leaders from 12 bike advocacy groups meet at Thunderhead Ranch in Wyoming to swap ideas and talk shop. They eventually form the Thunderhead Alliance, which grows to include some 160 biking and walking advocacy groups from around the country. It is now known as the Alliance for Biking & Walking.

Randy Neufeld ▶

The BikeFed, as it came to be known, never became a household name and it never bothered to become a mass member organization. But for years the Bicycle Federation played a big behind-the-scenes role in boosting bicycle transportation.

The federation sponsored an influential biennial meeting, now known as Pro Walk/Pro Bike and it became one of the main gathering points for bike advocates. Wilkinson, who ran the group for more than two decades before his 2008 retirement, helped form the coalition that outmatched the highway builders and finally gave biking and walking a share of federal transportation money. The group played the midwife role in creating the Thunderhead Alliance – now known as the Alliance for Biking & Walking – that represents and nurtures some 160 local bike advocacy groups across the US and Canada.

Above the border, John Luton, a City of Victoria councilor and executive director of the Capital Bike and Walk Society in Victoria, was busy sending out feelers to the bike community, NGOs and government officials, with the intent of creating a more cohesive movement in Canada and North America. The first Canadian to join the Alliance, Luton led the campaign to bring the Pro Walk/Pro Bike conference of 2004 to Victoria, BC.

Burden, the first director of the BikeFed, launched a bike-centennial, which led to the creation of the Adventure Cycling Association – now 44,500 members strong, mostly from North America. Eventually, Burden became a consultant who travels more than 300 days a year teaching people how to create walkable communities.

He hasn't forgotten his cycling roots. He likes, for example, to tell groups there are several good reasons to stripe in bike lanes besides just aiding cyclists. (Among them: providing space on the side of the roadway for emergency vehicles and moving motorized traffic further away from pedestrians.)

Wilkinson remembers the 70s as a time when the pioneering bike advocates

approached their work with an almost innocent fervor. In a society that had seen such rapid cultural shifts, from the rise of civil rights to the sexual revolution, why couldn't bikes be a tool for remaking cities?

"We had a change-the-world mentality," he said. "Nothing was impossible." For the most part, these early pioneers had little engineering or planning expertise. Still, with an energy crisis looming in the 1970s, they did manage to persuade Congress to order the federal government to study the potential gasoline savings of shifting shorter trips from cars to bikes. Several communities, particularly such college towns as Davis, CA and Eugene, OR, installed bike paths, bike lanes and other amenities to encourage cycling.

John Dowlin, a Philadelphia bike activist who helped market the now-ubiquitous inverted-U bicycle rack, for many years operated a clipping service that distributed news articles about bicycling issues.

Dowlin said that huge bike rides by environmental activists in Paris and London inspired American activists in the 70s. So did the demonstrations for better biking conditions in Amsterdam and Copenhagen. He also recalled the excitement over a 1973 article in *Scientific American* by Stuart S. Wilson – titled "Bicycle Technology" – that explained how the bike was the most efficient form of transportation.

Ivan Illich, a Roman Catholic priest, used the article for his landmark book *Energy and Equity*, which served as a radical manifesto for the bike movement.

The tumult of the 1970s, however, did not produce a bicycling revolution.

The bike industry, often only a faint-hearted supporter of bike advocacy, foundered as sales tanked in the mid-1970s and American companies began losing sales to overseas competitors.

Bike activists faced their own schism. John Forester, a California engineer and avid cyclist, started his own movement to fight bikeways, saying that authorities just wanted to deny cyclists the right to the road.

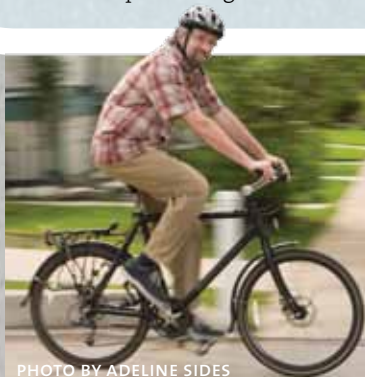


PHOTO BY ADELINE SIDES

1996: The US Surgeon General issues a landmark report on physical fitness that says the "major barrier to physical activity is the age in which we live." Among other things, it calls for replacing short car trips with biking and walking. A survey included in the report found that 53 percent of those who had cycled in the last year would ride to work if they could do so on "safe, separated designated paths."



Nancy Smith-Lea ▶

Forester produced a book, *Effective Cycling*, which codified the style of riding he had learned as a child in Great Britain – he was the son of novelist C.S. Forester – and as a reader of British cycling magazines. “Cyclists fare best,” he intoned, “when they act and are treated as drivers of vehicles.”

Vehicular cycling, as described by Forester, became the basis for bike education in North America. Even some of his sternest enemies give him credit for his vehicular cycling precepts and for helping protect the right of cyclists to use the public right of way. But he had a stormy tenure on the board of the League of American Wheelmen and alienated many bike advocates with his withering critiques.

Perhaps most importantly, Forester didn’t look to put North Americans on bikes. He was a suburbanite himself and saw little reason why large numbers of people would want to swap driving for pedaling. “It was a minority activity

“No longer is it a small group of outsiders meeting in the Golden Temple.”

and I didn’t expect it to be any more than that,” he told me years later, “because I knew the difficulty. It was real fun, but on the other hand...it had its costs, time and social opprobrium and such.”

Oil prices dropped in the early 1980s as the Reagan administration shut down the already minimal federal spending on bike projects. The shift to suburbia continued to accelerate and commutes grew longer. Several local bike groups withered. Cars got bigger as they morphed into mobile living rooms and roads became even more swollen with traffic.

The pivotal moment for biking’s rebound came in 1991 when Congress passed the Intermodal Surface Transportation Efficiency Act, known universally as ISTEA (pronounced “ice tea”).

With the interstate freeway system nearly complete by the end of the 1980s, a broad group of transportation reformers decided to hijack the “highway bill.” Those included transit interests, urban planning groups, bike activists and plenty of others who were used to getting shoved into the margins. They formed the Surface Transportation Policy Project, but their informal name was an ironic one: “the losers’ coalition.”

They enlisted a key senator, New York Democrat Daniel Patrick Moynihan, who had a lively career as a public intellectual before turning to elective politics. Among his work was a 1960 article, “New Roads and Urban Chaos,” that predicted the problems that would occur when states began ramming freeways through cities with the federal government picking up 90 percent of the tab.

With a real stream of federal money available, the bike lobby flowered. Now that local and state governments could apply for grants to build bikeways, politicians and bureaucrats showed a new interest in biking. And local bike advocacy groups could realistically push for new projects, whether it was a trail or an improved bridge crossing. Similarly, the bike industry realized that it needed to do more to make sure cycling captured these new federal dollars. Simply put, bike paths equaled more sales.

Another signature moment came in 1996 when some 20 activists from a dozen local bike groups around the country gathered at Thunderhead Ranch in Wyoming.

Jeff Miller, in his first week on the job as executive director of the Bicycle Coalition of Maine, was one of them. “That weekend was absolutely transforming,” he said, as the activists bonded and realized how common their problems were, from city to city.

Miller said his member groups had the equivalent of about 10 paid staffers in the late 1990s. Now, there are more than 200 – showing how much more professional the movement has become.

Hubsmith, who is now executive director



◀ Deb Hubsmith

2005: Congress passes a new transportation bill that gives cycling a huge win. Lawmakers approve \$600-million to start a Safe Routes to School program aimed at getting more children to walk and ride to school. The multifaceted program helps teach kids how to bicycle and increases the safety of streets around schools. The bill also includes a \$100-million pilot program to see if the mode share for bicycling can be increased in four communities: Minneapolis, MN; Marin County, CA; Columbia, MO; and Sheboygan County, WI.

2003: Congressional Republicans make a major effort to dump federal funding for a wide variety of bikeway projects. With the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy and a coalition of bike groups taking the lead, the effort is defeated on a 327-90 vote in the House. The big victory awakens Washington to the emerging power of the bike lobby. Below photo courtesy Transportation Alternatives



2000: The Robert Wood Johnson Foundation, which played such a major role in the anti-smoking movement, launches several programs to “Reengineer activity back into people’s lives.” Efforts such as Active Living by Design funnel millions to researchers and bicycle and walking advocates.

◀ Andy Clark



Jeffrey Miller ▶



◀ John Burke



1997: At the Interbike, trade show in Las Vegas, Trek Bicycles chairman John Burke pledges \$100,000 to bike advocacy efforts. Photo courtesy Trek Bicycle Corporation

1999: The League of American Bicyclists – founded in 1880 as the League of American Wheelmen – holds first National Bike Summit in Washington, DC.

1996: After being hit by a car in 1992, Nancy Smith-Lea, now the program director of the Toronto Coalition for Active Transportation, co-founded Advocacy for Respect for Cyclists (ARC). ARC supplied legal support for two cyclists arrested at a Critical Mass ride and called for a coroner’s inquest into the deaths of two other cyclists that occurred that same week. The CM cyclists were acquitted of the charges against them and the coroner’s inquest culminated in a ground-breaking report that became a touchstone for individuals and organizations endorsing safer roads for all in Canada and the US.



Jim Oberstar ~

2006: Democrats take control of Congress. Rep. Jim Oberstar, the sponsor of the Safe Routes to School program, becomes the chairman of the House Transportation Committee. Oberstar, a cyclist who says he wants to shift the country from the "hydrocarbon economy to the carbohydrate economy," is increasingly well-positioned to do something about it. Photo by John Schadt



• John Luton

2007: Janette Sadik-Kahn becomes commissioner of transportation in New York City. Sadik-Kahn, a strong believer in reallocating urban streetscapes away from the automobile, aggressively builds New York City's bike network. And she attracts national headlines in 2009 by closing much of Broadway to auto traffic.

Yvonne Bambrick •

Photo by Rannie Turingan

2008: Barack Obama is elected president. He becomes the first US leader to promote bicycling in his campaign platform, which states: "Our communities will better serve all of their residents if we are able to leave our cars, to walk, bicycle and have access other transportation alternatives."

2009: The National Association of City Transportation Officials launches Cities for Cycling, an effort to lobby for federal approval of new bikeway treatments and to help cities boost their cycling rates.

Mark Gorton ~



of the Safe Routes to School National Partnership, cited two other key events that helped produce a muscular bike lobby.

In the late 1990s, the bike industry—spurred on by John Burke, the chairman of Trek Bicycles—formed Bikes Belong and played a key role in pushing through new funding for biking and walking in ISTE's successor, the Transportation Efficiency Act of 1998.

And in 2003, the various bike groups—working as one in a coalition called America Bikes—demolished an attempt by conservative Republicans to eliminate funding for the program that provided hundreds of millions of dollars for bike and pedestrian projects.

Of course, it wasn't all just sharp lobbying. The revitalization of inner cities around North America helped spur interest in alternative forms of transportation—and many people discovered that bikes were a great way to cover relatively short urban trips. The obesity crisis turned the public health community into cheerleaders for integrating activity into peoples' daily lives. The new buzzword for biking and walking was "active transportation." And, of course, peak oil and global warming became common concerns over the last decade. In many ways, the bike movement has started to shift. No longer is it a small group of outsiders meeting in the Golden Temple.

Oberstar, who credits bicycling with helping him recover emotionally from the death of his first wife from cancer, now chairs the House Transportation Committee, and cycling activists are hoping to win big boosts in funding for safe routes to school and other bike programs in the next transportation bill. Congressman Earl Blumenauer, who helped create Portland's bike network when he was on that city's council, has stitched together a Congressional Bike Caucus of some 160 members.

Janette Sadik-Kahn, the innovative transportation commissioner for New York City, accomplished more in less than three years on the job than bike activists would have once dreamed possible. Barack Obama became the first US president to include bicycling in his transportation platform. His transportation secretary, Raymond LaHood, told me last year on a trip to Portland how impressed he was with the number of cyclists he saw in the city [see our Portland feature, p. 32]. He also praised the city's growing streetcar and light rail lines and said the way to fix cities was simple: "Take what you've done here in Portland and try to replicate it around America. It's not that complicated."

The bike movement has broadened in

many ways, adopting a more sophisticated view of urban design and transportation. The Chicagoland Bicycle Federation, for example, now calls itself the Active Transportation Alliance. It envisions a community where half of all trips are by bicycling, walking and transit.

Wilkinson, one of the pioneers of the movement, talked about how he gradually began to change his focus from bikes to land use.

"If you don't get the bones of the community right, the rest of it isn't going to work," he explained. "For bicycling and walking to be viable modes to support daily routines and activities, the origins and destinations have to be in reasonable proximity. They can't be eight-mile trips."

Many of the new stars of the bike movement would never be confused with Lance Armstrong.

There's John Pucher, a professor at Rutgers, who spent much of his career studying mass transit. Since a 1996 sabbatical in Muenster, Germany, where bikes are as common as cars, he's authored influential studies on how to bring European-style urban biking levels to North America. And there's Todd Litman of the Victoria Transport Institute in British Columbia, one of the major theorists showing how North America needs to shift away from an auto-centric transportation system. And Yvonne Bambrick, executive director of the Toronto Cyclists Union (and piloting the tandem bike on our cover)—has gathered support for her city's first and only membership-based organization that launched in May 2008, signing up 1,100 members to date. Through her collaborative and inclusive style of advocacy, combined with media savvy communications skills, Yvonne has mainstreamed the conversation about transportation cycling. Ongoing campaigns include updating the *Ontario Driver's Handbook*, a Complete Streets Policy campaign in partnership with the Toronto Coalition for Active Transportation, and Newcomer Cycling Outreach program in partnership with CultureLink Settlement Services. Or you could point to Mark Gorton, a high-tech finance entrepreneur in New York City who has financed two influential web sites, Streetsblog and Streetfilms, which have become major news sources for bike activists.

Miller, who heads the Alliance for Biking & Walking, notes that the 160 local bike groups in his coalition still only have around 100,000 members.

"I find that to be rather dismal, personally," said Miller. "The big thing I always state is to join your local organization, get involved. ... If everyone spent just a fraction of what they spent on their bicycles and equipment, there would be a profound payoff for that investment." 